

Siphoning money virtually

We'd mentioned about the security hazards that plague WiFi (802.11b) networks in our September 2001 issue. Apparently the industry takes a while to wake up to security threats.

The latest casualty of hacker troubles is **Bestbuy.com**. It had to suspend the use of wireless cash registers after an anonymous user on **Securityfocus.com**'s e-mail list claimed to have obtained a credit card



number from Bestbuy's wireless system.

Although these networks are the latest must-haves, there

are several issues to be ironed out—security being foremost.

As we had mentioned in the story, a hacker with basic equipment such as a laptop with wireless transceivers and packet sniffing software can easily gain access to these networks. Bestbuy's case is no different.

Mera wala LCD paint

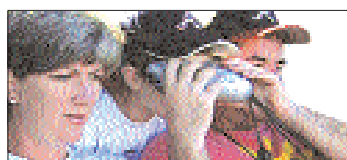
Imagine watches and pagers that can be painted onto your shirt! Or wall papers that change shades when you press a button. Sounds like something out of a sci-fi movie? All this is possible with paint-on Liquid Crystal Display (LCD) technology. This technology has been developed by Dirk Broer of Philips, Netherlands. Liquid crystals are usually sandwiched between two glass plates. When electricity is applied to these crystals, they change colour and become dark. This technology is expensive and does not allow screen sizes of more than one square metre.

However, Broer and his team have come up with a way to deposit liquid crystal layers on single sheets. They have already succeeded in making prototypes by depositing liquid crystal layers on glass and plastic. Cloth is next on their agenda. If this technology succeeds, it could help create cheap lightweight laptops, giant display walls that change colour, and so on. Way to go, Broer and team!

Outside, yet inside

Nothing beats the thrill of being at the cricket stadium and watching the match firsthand. But at the stadium, you end up wishing you were sitting in front of a TV while trying to figure out whether Sachin Tendulkar was run out or not.

This is where a new wireless gizmo featured at baseball



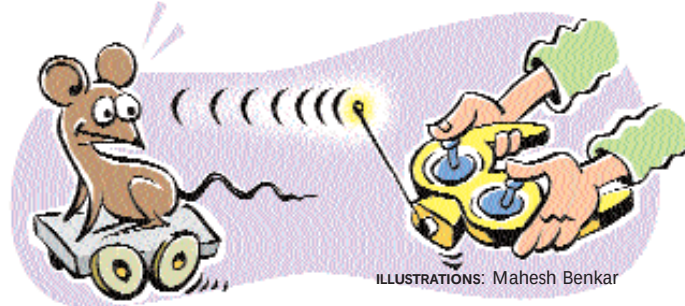
stadiums in the US comes to your aid. Christened 'The Insider', it offers personal instant replays from multiple

cameras. If you are bored with the game, you can use the other three of the four channels to see the news or other programs. It looks like a pair of binoculars and comes along with earphones and has a battery powered receiver at the belt. The Insider is rented out for \$20 (approx Rs 1,000) per game.

Remote-controlled rats

Rats that do what we command them to? That's what John Chapin, Professor of Physiology and Pharmacology at the State University of New York in Brooklyn has achieved.

He, along with a team of researchers, implanted five rats with electrodes in their brain and provided them with battery backpacks. These electrodes provide pulses generated by a laptop computer to the rats' brains so that they can be remotely controlled to go wherever one wants them to go. Whenever researchers



want the rats to move in a particular direction, pulses are provided to specific locations of the brain. They are then rewarded by stimulating a pleasure centre in their brain. These rats are intended to

help search for survivors trapped in collapsed buildings. Although such experiments sound exciting, there are ethical concerns too. Imagine remote-controlled human beings!

snapshot

115 Dotcom shutdowns between Jan and Feb 2001
37 shutdowns between Jan and Feb 2002

Source: www.webmergers.com